

An acquired buried penis is when an adult's penis becomes **hidden under the skin and fat** of the lower belly or scrotum. It can cause trouble keeping clean, skin infections, trouble urinating standing up, and problems with sex. It is a known problem that surgery can often fix.

About This Condition

"Acquired" means it started in adulthood. Common causes include **weight gain** with a heavy fat pad above the penis, scarring from circumcision or other surgery, long-term swelling of the skin (**lymphedema**), and a scarring skin disease called **lichen sclerosis**.

It tends to get worse over time:

- Trapped skin stays wet and gets **irritated and infected**.
- Urine on the trapped skin adds to the irritation and scarring.
- Keeping clean, urinating and sex get harder.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

about

9 in 10

still have an unburied penis 1 year after surgery

3–5 in 10

have a problem after surgery, mostly minor wound problems

1–2 in 10

find the penis becomes buried again over time

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

Why Repair Helps

Surgery aims to **free the penis**, remove diseased skin, and rebuild healthy skin cover. Most men urinate and keep clean more easily afterward, and most say they would have the surgery again. The risk of problems is higher with a very high weight, diabetes, smoking and frailty.

Learn the Terms

Buried (hidden) penis

A normal penis hidden under the skin and fat around it.

Escutcheonectomy

Removing the fat pad just above the penis.

Panniculectomy

Removing the apron of skin and fat that hangs from the lower belly.

Skin graft

A thin layer of healthy skin moved to cover the shaft of the penis.

Donor site

The place the skin graft is taken from, such as the thigh or the removed fat pad.

Lichen sclerosis

A scarring skin disease that can cause or worsen a buried penis.

Lymphedema

Long-term swelling of the skin from fluid that does not drain well.

Will I need to lose weight first? Losing weight lowers the risk of problems and helps the result last, so your team will encourage it. It is not always required, and you should not wait forever: the condition keeps causing harm. Weight loss alone does not undo scarring or loose skin.

First days Some go home the same or next day. Others stay longer.	First week or so A dressing protects the graft. You may have a catheter and drains.	Next weeks Wound care at home. Small wound problems are common.	Later Sex once your team says the area has healed. Keep up weight control.
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How the Repair Is Done

- 1 The penis is **freed** from the scar and tissue that trap it.
- 2 Diseased or scarred skin is removed and sent to the lab. The shaft is often covered with a **skin graft**.
- 3 The fat pad above the penis is removed. Some men also need the belly apron removed or the scrotum reshaped.
- 4 Some repairs are done in **stages**. A narrow urethra may be treated at the same time.

How to Get Ready

- Work on **weight** and **stop smoking**. Get your blood sugar under control if you have diabetes.
- Any skin infection is treated first.
- Arrange help at home and time off work.

After Surgery

- If you have a graft, **protect it** from rubbing and pressure as your team directs.
- Grafted skin usually has less light-touch feeling. Erections usually still work.

Call the office that did your surgery if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Redness that spreads, or bad-smelling drainage
- A graft or wound that turns dark or opens

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate, or the catheter stops draining, and your bladder feels full or painful
- Heavy bleeding that does not stop with firm pressure
- Chest pain, trouble breathing, or a swollen, painful leg
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. A buried penis can often be repaired, and most men are glad they had surgery.
2. Weight loss and not smoking lower the risks.
3. Wound problems are common. Most are minor, but call if a wound opens.